

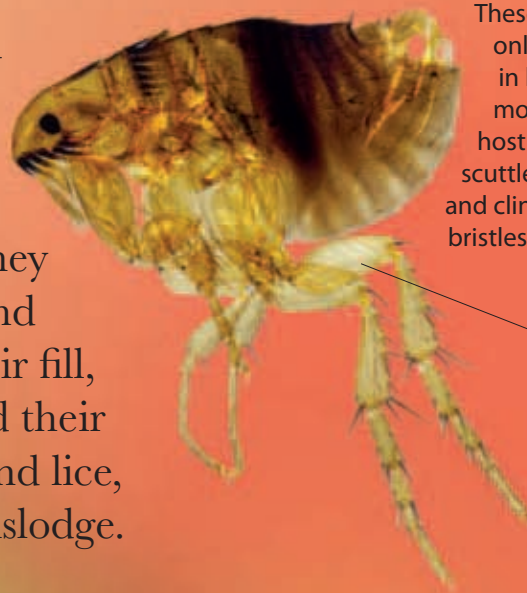
Feeding on blood

Blood is the ideal meal for many animals—it is rich in all kinds of nutrients, and it is easy to digest. Some of the world's most numerous insects feed on blood, particularly at breeding times. Most bloodsucking animals have mouthparts that pierce or slice through skin, and many produce substances that prevent blood from clotting as they feed. Some blood-feeders, such as mosquitoes and vampire bats, move on once they have eaten their fill, but others, known as parasites, often stay aboard their hosts. These hitchhikers, including fleas, ticks, and lice, have tough bodies and can be very difficult to dislodge.

Jumping aboard

Fleas are wingless insects that live on the bodies of mammals and birds, where they suck the blood of their hosts.

These tiny parasites measure only 0.04– $\frac{1}{3}$ in (1–8 mm) in length, yet they can leap more than 12 in (30 cm) from host to host. Once aboard, fleas scuttle through fur or feathers and cling on safely using the long bristles that cover their bodies.



Bulging hind-leg muscles power the flea's jumps

Microscopic view of a cat flea

Stealthy jab

This female mosquito is sucking human blood and has almost finished its meal. The insect drinks through a set of sharp-tipped mouthparts, which work like an ultra-fine syringe. In addition to attacking humans, mosquitoes drink the blood of many wild animals, and they often spread fatal diseases as they feed. However, only the females are bloodsuckers—male mosquitoes live on the sugary juices, or nectar, produced by flowers.

Piercing mouthparts enter skin

Body segments stretch as abdomen fills with blood

